

- More particular and educated – especially politically left-leaning – viewers would enjoy the social and political issues explored, and the alternative view of British history.
- Traditionally masculine viewers would identify with (and admire) the tough, no-nonsense male characters, whilst respecting their strict codes and moral values.
- Female viewers, especially with feminist values, would admire the strong and complex female characters that defy stereotypes.

Consider theoretical approaches

Reception theory – Stuart Hall:

Hall asserts that individual audience members will interpret media texts in different ways according to their established **values and beliefs**. He believed there were three modes of ‘reception’, where audiences **decode** what they consume.

- **Dominant/intended meaning:** the audience accepts the intended meanings and ideology of the text’s producers. In the case of *Peaky Blinders*, this would be viewers who agree with and enjoy the valorisation of working-class lives and history.
- **Negotiated meaning:** the audience accept some of the intended meaning but reject others. Some viewers may enjoy the depictions of industrial areas as vibrant and exciting but may find the stylised violence upsetting.
- **Oppositional meaning:** the audience reject the intended meaning and instead formulate their own interpretation. They may find style of the show off-putting and superficial and the historical accuracy dubious (factually, the *Blinders* mainly operated in the late 1800s, not the 1920s). They may also reject the use of anachronistic punk and rock music annoying.
- *Peaky Blinders* has been credited with fuelling a cultural Renaissance in Birmingham (and the other Midlands filming locations). Knight has spoken about a ‘cultural cringe’ in this locality. He wrote *Peaky Blinders* to address this and ‘mythologise a geographical area, a period of history and class of people who are never normally focused on in this way.’
- These uniqueness (but also the universal appeal) of these portrayals has led to fans from all over the UK flocking to the Midlands – often in full costume – to go to theme pubs, tours, educational events, museums, and art gallery shows. There was a *Peaky Blinders* Festival in Digbeth attended by 20,000 people – including the Mayor of Birmingham – in costume.
- This is what is known as a ‘**cottage industry**’ – unofficial, ‘satellite’ products that provide fans with an extended experience beyond the TV screen.
- There are social media groups around the world dedicated to *Peaky Blinder* cosplay. Look at the #peakyblinders threads on TikTok or another platform.
- There is also a wealth of fanart and fanfiction available. This what Jenkins refers to as ‘**textual poaching**’ – non-professional producers (‘**prosumers**’) sampling bigger cultural products and using them as a basis for their own creativity, then distributing them outside the network (or control) of the institutions that produced the original text.

Fandom – Henry Jenkins:

- Jenkins asserts that fandom is deeply personal and **creative relationship** with media products. He believes that particularly genre films and TV can unite marginalised people and even be **appropriated** for political purposes (e.g. the use of the three finger salute from *The Hunger Games* by Hong Kong democratic protestors).